
West Africa Regional Policy Dialogue on Adaptation Accountability and the Global Goal on Adaptation (GGA): Report

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1.0 Executive Summary

The West Africa Regional Policy Dialogue on Adaptation Accountability and the Global Goal on Adaptation was convened on 6 May 2026 at the University of Ghana, bringing together researchers, government practitioners, civil society representatives, and regional scientists to assess the relevance and feasibility of the approved GGA indicators from a West African perspective. Three thematic panel sessions revealed that accountability in climate adaptation across the sub-region flows predominantly toward donors and national reporting bodies rather than toward the communities most exposed to climate risk, compounded by fragmented institutional coordination and data poverty at sub-national scales. Empirical research from northern Ghana showed that participatory project frameworks frequently give communities responsibility without authority, producing compliance rather than genuine participation. Participants converged on three priorities: institutionalising co-production across the adaptation project cycle, investing in locally owned data infrastructure, and formalising community feedback mechanisms within adaptation governance.

2.0 Dialogue Overview

2.1 Background

The West Africa Regional Policy Dialogue on Adaptation Accountability and the Global Goal on Adaptation was held on 6 May 2026 at the West African Centre for Crop Improvement (WACCI), University of Ghana, Accra. It was convened by ARIN as part of a series of regional dialogues across Africa, forming the third phase of the Accountable Adaptation project, a five-year research programme implemented in collaboration with University College London. This phase is designed to translate empirical findings from the Accountable Adaptation Fellows into policy-relevant insights, focusing on assessing the relevance, feasibility, and limitations of the GGA indicators approved at COP29 from African policy and practice perspectives, and to feed those perspectives into the ongoing global GGA indicator implementation process.

2.2 Participants

The dialogue brought together 28 participants representing academic and research institutions, government extension services, regional science bodies, civil society organisations, and independent climate adaptation professionals. Represented institutions included the University of Ghana, the West African Science Service Centre

on Climate Change and Adapted Land Use (WASCAL), the CSIR Crop Research Institute, Ghana's Directorate of Agricultural Extension

Services, and JVE (Young Volunteers for the Environment) from Togo. ARIN's coordinating team participated virtually from Nairobi, and the Accountable Adaptation Fellow from Ghana presented field research findings from northern Ghana.

2.3 Format

The dialogue was conducted in a hybrid format, with 22 participants physically present at WACCI in Accra and 6 joining virtually. The session comprised framing presentations by two senior researchers, three moderated panel discussions, a dedicated presentation by the Accountable Adaptation Fellow, and a closing synthesis session, with structured opportunities for both in person and virtual participants to contribute throughout.

3.0 Key Discussion Themes

3.1 How Accountability is Understood and Operationalised

Participants defined accountability in ways shaped by their institutional positions, but a common finding ran through all perspectives: accountability in climate adaptation across West Africa is predominantly upward, flowing from implementing agencies toward donors and international reporting bodies rather than downward toward communities. Academic researchers framed this as a governance and justice question, noting that reporting happens at the national and ministerial level while communities receive very little accountability in return. The government practitioner described her directorate's Research Extension Linkages Community platform as a practical attempt at downward accountability, convening farmers, researchers, and value chain actors to identify needs and develop joint action plans, while acknowledging its limited scale. The civil society representative stated that accountability remains oriented toward donors and governments and described her organisation's role as a bridge between policy spaces and lived realities, including through shadow reporting when official accounts fail to reflect community inputs. The regional science representative argued that accountability must assess whether adaptation systems are achieving their aims, not merely whether activities have been completed.

All participants agreed that top-down accountability structures dominate, that community voice is inadequately institutionalised, and that co-production from the

project design stage is the most viable pathway toward genuine downward accountability. The principal divergence was one of degree: academic researchers acknowledged incremental improvements in global frameworks while the civil society representative conveyed a more urgent assessment of the gap between formal commitments and community realities. The main barriers identified were donor-driven reporting requirements, power asymmetries that prevent communities from questioning implementing institutions, absent downward feedback mechanisms, institutional fragmentation across sectoral bodies, weak district-level staff capacity, and cultural norms that discourage community members from holding institutions to account.

3.2 Relevance and Feasibility of GGA Indicators

Participants consistently identified thematic clusters most relevant to West Africa's dominant climate risks. Researchers pointed to vulnerability reduction, adaptive capacity, food and water security, locally led adaptation, and ecosystem-based approaches as directly aligned with work across coastal, urban, and semi-arid contexts in the region. The regional science representative emphasised that relevance is inherently sector-dependent and that meaningful indicator prioritisation requires simultaneous engagement across agriculture, water, disaster risk, and health sectors. The most consistently cited practical constraint was data resolution: the approved GGA indicators draw on datasets calibrated at scales that do not correspond to sub-national realities. For instance, it was highlighted that Ghana has only 21 synoptic meteorological stations, with districtlevel assemblies lacking the localised data needed to measure adaptation progress meaningfully. Furthermore, participants cited data quality, collection frequency, and the tendency of donorfunded data collection to serve funder research priorities rather than local decision-making utility.

In general, four gaps were identified in the current GGA framework: autonomous community adaptation practices are systematically uncounted; maladaptation is not measured; social resilience and community-defined wellbeing resist quantitative measurement conventions; and, most fundamentally, communities are not involved in defining what indicators matter to them. The civil society representative argued that communities should be positioned as co-owners of accountability rather than as its objects, and that without their participation in indicator design, the measurement exercise misses its own purpose.

3.3 Evidence, Transparency, and Feedback Mechanisms

Participants drew a consistent distinction between scientific data, which dominates formal reporting, and community-generated knowledge, which is more proximate to

adaptation realities but systematically undervalued. The crop research representative defined credible evidence for policy purposes as data that signifies change over time, collected with community participation, and validated by the people it concerns. One participant proposed blended knowledge systems combining meteorological data with indigenous seasonal indicators as a practical model for integrating scientific and community knowledge in ways that strengthen the credibility of both. On transparency, the Fellow's research found it strong where it served the implementing institution's operational objectives and weak or absent on budgets, input criteria, and project decisions. The regional science representative identified co-production as the mechanism through which transparency becomes structurally embedded, and pointed to the Global Framework for Climate Services, already launched in Ghana, as an existing structure whose pillars directly address the transparency and data gaps identified in the discussion.

On feedback, participants identified a wide gap between what currently exists and what is needed. The government practitioner described farm visits and farmer group meetings as the primary methods used by her directorate, constrained by staff numbers and difficulty translating community concerns into policy-usable formats. The Fellow argued that feedback must be institutionalised within formal project cycles rather than left subject to filtering by intermediaries, and the crop research representative recommended integrating adaptation reporting into existing national systems and using digital tools to transmit field-level evidence upward. The ARIN coordinator proposed that National Adaptation Plans should require participatory validation, where community members interpret and prioritise data before submission to national level, as a practical mechanism for linking GGA reporting to local feedback loops.

4.0 Spotlight on Fellow's Research

The Accountable Adaptation Fellow from Ghana presented findings from a qualitative study of the Accelerating Impacts of CGIAR Climate Research for Africa (AICCRA) project in the Kumbungu and Tolon communities of northern Ghana. The project sought to build smallholder farmer groups' capacity in the use of climate information systems and climate-smart agricultural practices. Using focus group discussions and key informant interviews, the research examined interactions between formal implementing institutions and informal beneficiary groups across three accountability types: upward, downward, and horizontal.

The central finding was that horizontal accountability among beneficiaries, superficially resembling community participation, had in practice become a

mechanism for enforcing compliance with externally defined project priorities. Farmers monitored each other's adherence to prescribed practices, and attendance at project meetings was policed among peers because future project support was tied to group compliance scores. Transparency was strong on technical guidance but absent on budgets, input allocation, and project decisions. The research concluded that responsibility had been decentralised to communities while authority had not and drew four policy implications: aligning responsibility with authority; institutionalising community feedback within project cycles; expanding financial transparency to beneficiaries; and negotiating project priorities with communities before designs are finalised.

The Fellow's research anchored the broader dialogue by providing community-level evidence for what other participants had described in structural terms. His documentation of uneven transparency grounded the civil society argument that accountability flows predominantly upward, and his finding that participation can collapse into compliance illustrated the consensus that coproduction must be structural rather than rhetorical. The regional science representative's observation that donor funding conditions effectively reduce local actors to implementers of external agendas reinforced the case that accountability for adaptation cannot be separated from accountability for adaptation financing.

5.0 Region-Specific Implications and Recommendations

5.1 For Regional Adaptation Governance

For ECOWAS, the findings point to the need for a regional coordination framework that moves beyond harmonising reporting formats toward mandating integration across the fragmented sectoral bodies, agriculture, water, disaster risk reduction, and health, that currently operate in silos, and toward collective investment in the data infrastructure deficit common across member states. Governments and regional actors should strengthen mechanisms that support coordination among public institutions, research organisations, civil society actors, and development partners. Furthermore, governments should establish clear expectations that local government actors retain their community-facing mandate within adaptation projects regardless of external funding arrangements and should invest in district-level data collection capacity and digital reporting infrastructure. Again, existing structures such as extension services, community organisations, and local governance institutions should be strengthened to ensure that communities can influence adaptation

priorities and provide feedback on interventions. Finally, improving transparency around adaptation financing, resource allocation, and implementation decisions was identified as another important step towards strengthening trust and accountability.

5.2 For the GGA Process

The West Africa dialogue carries four messages for the global stage. First, the GGA process must create space for locally validated indicators grounded in data that African countries can realistically generate. Second, national GGA reporting should be required to demonstrate how community members contributed to defining and verifying the data on which reports are based. Third, the framework must shift from measuring activity outputs toward measuring outcomes and incorporate mechanisms for identifying maladaptation. Fourth, accountability for adaptation financing must be brought within the scope of global accountability frameworks, as donor funding conditions that override community priorities will otherwise continue unchecked.

5.3 Emerging Priorities

Three priority areas emerged from the dialogue. The first is the institutionalisation of coproduction across the full adaptation project cycle, ensuring communities hold decision-making authority and that project priorities are negotiated before designs are finalised. The second is investment in locally owned, high-resolution data systems, including expanding automatic weather station networks, building district-level reporting capacity, and integrating community-based monitoring into national data systems, coordinated through the Global Framework for Climate Services already existing in various phases in all countries across the West African subregion. Finally, another priority area is the formalisation of downward feedback mechanisms within all adaptation projects, building community capacity to communicate assessments in policy-useable formats and recognising civil society shadow reporting as a legitimate accountability instrument alongside official government reports.



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